

Heroes and villains

A good story needs to have interesting characters that the reader cares about. Usually, there is a main character, or hero. There are also villains, who stop the hero from reaching his or her goals, and allies, who help the hero. Each character should be distinctive, with unique physical or personality traits.



The perfect setting

The setting is the time, place, and situation where the action happens. The right setting will give the story mood and atmosphere. For example, a pirate story could be set on a deserted tropical island in the seventeenth century. Describing a setting in detail will enable the reader to imagine what it is like.



The island was **deserted**, except for the **multicolored** birds **circling** overhead. The **golden** sandy beach was **fringed** with **coconut** trees and **tropical** plants. A **ghostly** shipwreck in the distance was being **pounded** against the **craggy** rocks by **crashing** waves.

Words that contain description, such as sounds, paint a vivid picture of the scene.

Dramatic dialogue

Using dialogue in a story can reveal more about the characters and advance the plot. It should be concise and dramatic—overly long or pointless pieces of dialogue should be avoided. Choosing phrases such as *he grumbled*, *he screamed*, or *he gasped* instead of *he said* also adds more drama.

Pieces of dialogue need to go in quotation marks.

“Is that you, Captain?” shouted the first mate.

“Of course it is. Now, hurry up and lower a boat to fetch me,” bellowed the captain.

A new speaker's dialogue needs to go on a new line.

Use more interesting words as an alternative to *said*.



- Use a mixture of **long** and **short** sentences to build up **tension** and **suspense**.

- **Figurative language** such as the simile *as fast as a cheetah* can enrich the description in a narrative. However, use it **sparingly**—too much description can **distract** the reader from the action.